He added: ‘I have made myself unpopular with all Mahomedans on your account yet you have not comprehended this. Please understand. They say that I wish to destroy the true faith. This is an affair affecting life and death . . . God deliver me.’[63]

Major-General George Pollock was not a man who liked to be rushed. His reputation had been built on careful planning and meticulous logistics, and following the catastrophe of the slaughter of the Kabul army in January he was all the more determined not to be bullied into acting a single moment before he was ready. Sir Jasper Nicholls, the Commander-in-Chief in Calcutta, was entirely behind him in this, writing to London that ‘It was as well that a cool, cautious officer of the Company’s army’ should have the command. ‘Any precipitancy on the part of a general officer panting for fame might now have the worst effect.’[64]

Pollock had arrived in Peshawar on 5 February to find morale at rock bottom and many of the sepoys hospitalised: no fewer than 1,800 were on the sick list, and as the trickle of frostbitten survivors of the retreat limped and crawled into Peshawar with their stories of defeat and desertion by their officers, the atmosphere grew increasingly mutinous. Pollock knew he had to turn this around and immediately set about reassuring the sepoys. His first action was to issue worsted gloves and stockings to keep them from the cold. ‘I shall visit the hospitals frequently,’ he explained to Nicholls, ‘and by adding in any way to their comforts, show that I feel an interest in them.’ Soon the numbers of sick were decreasing by the day, and the atmosphere in the camp visibly improving.

Over the following two months, as more regiments and supply wagons arrived, he slowly assembled his forces and his provisions, riding out every day with his field glass to study the elaborate defences and stone sangars the Afridis were building across the Khyber to block his advance. He had calculated that he needed around 275,000 rounds of ammunition in order to bring his force up to 200 rounds per man, and these had all arrived by mid-March. Following desertions by his camel drivers he delayed another fortnight until he had the transport capacity he needed. He also wrote to Ferozepur requesting one more regiment of cavalry and several more traps of horse artillery. Meanwhile, to the increasingly desperate Sale in Jalalabad he wrote: ‘Your situation is never out of my mind . . . Necessity alone has